MR. LIFE MANAGER · FREE GUIDE

The First Apartment Checklist

Everything to do, buy, and find out — in the order you'll need it.

☐ Check it off — print this and use a pen ★ **You'll miss this in the first 24 hours**

PART 1 Before you sign

15 minutes

Fifteen minutes here saves months later.

READ THE LEASE — ALL OF IT

Yes, really. Find these and write them down:

- ☐ Rent due date, and the late fee after it
- ☐ Length of the lease, and what happens at the end — does it auto-renew?
- ☐ **Notice required to move out** — usually 30 or 60 days. Miss it and you owe another month.
- ☐ What you pay for vs. what's included: water, trash, heat, electric, internet
- ☐ Rules on guests, pets, subletting, painting, and mounting things on walls
- ☐ How to submit a repair request, and who to call after hours
- ☐ Deposit amount, and the conditions for getting it back

ASK BEFORE YOU SIGN

- ☐ Which utilities do I set up, and with which companies?
- ☐ Is renter's insurance required? *(Get it either way — see Part 3.)*
- ☐ What's the parking situation, and is it extra?
- ☐ Which appliances are included, and who repairs them?
- ☐ Has anything in this unit recently been repaired or had a problem?

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> Almost every expensive surprise in a first apartment is written somewhere in the lease.... It's not that people agree to bad terms — it's that they never read them, so they don't know

PART 2 Before you move a single box

A week ahead

SET UP UTILITIES

- ☐ Electric
- ☐ Water & sewer *(often landlord)*
- ☐ **Internet** — book the install now; it's often 1–2 weeks out
- ☐ Gas
- ☐ Trash *(often landlord)*
- ☐ **Put it all on autopay** the day you set it up

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> Autopay is the cheapest thing you will ever do to protect your credit. One missed bill yo... never even saw can follow you for years.

CHANGE YOUR ADDRESS

- [ ] USPS mail forwarding
- [ ] Employer / payroll
- [ ] Vehicle registration
- [ ] Auto and health insurance
- [ ] Subscriptions that ship things
- [ ] School or student records
- [ ] Bank and credit cards
- [ ] Driver's license
- [ ] Voter registration
- [ ] Phone
- [ ] Doctor, dentist, pharmacy

PART 3 Move-in day, before you unpack

30 minutes

The most valuable half hour in this document. Do it before a single box comes in, while the place is still empty.

DOCUMENT THE CONDITION OF EVERYTHING

- [ ] **Photograph and video every room**, empty, with the date visible if you can
- [ ] Close-ups of every existing flaw: scuffs, stains, chips, holes, scratched floors, dinged counters, torn screens, cracked tiles
- [ ] Check and photograph inside the fridge and oven, under every sink, inside closets, window frames, and bathroom corners
- [ ] Fill out the move-in condition form if you got one. **If you didn't, email your landlord a list of what you found anyway** — and keep that email.
- [ ] Test every outlet, light switch, faucet (hot *and* cold), window, lock, and the toilet
- [ ] Run the shower five minutes — check drainage, and how long the hot water lasts

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> At move-out, the default assumption is that the damage is yours. Dated photos are how... you prove it wasn't. This routinely decides whether people get several hundred dollars

FIND THESE FIVE THINGS AND WRITE DOWN WHERE THEY ARE

- [ ] **Water shutoff valve** — for the whole unit, and under each sink and toilet
- [ ] **Breaker panel** — and which switch controls what
- [ ] **Water heater** — and whether it's yours or shared
- [ ] **Smoke and CO detectors** — where they are, and test each one now
- [ ] **Fire extinguisher** — where the nearest one is

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> You will not learn where the water shutoff is during a leak. You'll learn it after.

GET RENTER'S INSURANCE

- [ ] Usually around fifteen dollars a month. Cheap compared with replacing your stuff. Get it before you move in.

- [ ] **Your landlord's insurance covers the building, not your things.** If there's a fire, a burst pipe, or a break-in, this is what replaces your stuff.
- [ ] Photograph your valuables and keep the receipts somewhere that isn't the apartment

PART 4 The first shopping trip

Day one

Grouped by where things go. You don't need all of it on day one — the ★ items are what you'll miss first.

CLEANING — BUY THESE BEFORE YOU UNPACK

- [ ] ★ Paper towels
- [ ] ★ Dish soap
- [ ] All-purpose cleaner
- [ ] Sponges and microfiber cloths
- [ ] Broom and dustpan
- [ ] Mop and bucket
- [ ] Laundry detergent
- [ ] ★ Trash bags *(check the can size)*
- [ ] ★ Plunger
- [ ] Bathroom cleaner
- [ ] Toilet brush
- [ ] Vacuum or a good sweeper
- [ ] Rubber gloves
- [ ] Dryer sheets or wool balls

> **WHERE TO KEEP IT**
>
> Keep a small set of supplies *in each room where you use them*. A second cheap bottle of... bathroom cleaner buys a behavior change — the bathroom gets wiped when the supplies

KITCHEN

- [ ] ★ Dish soap, sponge, dish towels
- [ ] ★ One good knife
- [ ] Skillet
- [ ] Baking sheet
- [ ] Spatula, wooden spoon, tongs
- [ ] Colander
- [ ] Food storage containers
- [ ] Oven mitt
- [ ] ★ Can opener
- [ ] Cutting board
- [ ] Saucepan with a lid
- [ ] Mixing bowl
- [ ] Measuring cups and spoons
- [ ] Plates, bowls, cups, silverware
- [ ] Foil, plastic wrap, storage bags
- [ ] Dish rack

BATHROOM

- [ ] ★ Toilet paper
- [ ] ★ Shower curtain, liner, rings
- [ ] Bath mat
- [ ] Basic first aid kit
- [ ] ★ Hand soap
- [ ] Bath towels, hand towels, washcloths
- [ ] Trash can
- [ ] Any medication you take

BEDROOM

- [ ] ★ Sheets — two sets, so laundry day isn't a crisis
- [ ] Comforter or duvet
- [ ] Hangers
- [ ] Curtains or blinds, if the windows are bare
- [ ] ★ Pillows
- [ ] Mattress protector
- [ ] Laundry hamper
- [ ] Alarm clock

THE STUFF NOBODY PUTS ON THE LIST

- [ ] ★ Light bulbs *(check what fits first)*
- [ ] **Toolkit:** hammer, screwdriver with bits, tape measure, pliers, level, utility knife, adjustable wrench
- [ ] Extension cords, power strips
- [ ] Duct tape
- [ ] Step stool
- [ ] Air filters — **check the size on the existing one**
- [ ] ★ Batteries
- [ ] Command strips and picture hardware
- [ ] Flashlight
- [ ] Scissors
- [ ] Fire extinguisher *(kitchen-rated)*
- [ ] Drain hair catcher *(cheaper than a plumber, every time)*

PART 5 The first week

Days 1–7

- [ ] **Make your bed properly on night one.** Everything else can wait; sleeping well is what makes the rest of the week possible.
- [ ] Set up the kitchen before anything else — a working kitchen makes the place feel livable, and it's what stops the delivery spending
- [ ] **Give things a home as you unpack.** Unpacking is the only time you'll decide where things live from scratch. Don't waste it by stacking boxes.
- [ ] Put daily-use items at waist-to-eye height; rarely-used things go high or low
- [ ] Note the trash and recycling schedule, and where the bins go
- [ ] Find the nearest grocery store, pharmacy, urgent care, and laundromat
- [ ] Learn where mail is delivered and how packages are handled
- [ ] Meet at least one neighbor — worth more than it sounds when you're locked out
- [ ] Buy one week of groceries for **three or four meals you already know how to make**
- [ ] Test the smoke detectors; note the air filter size and set a reminder

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> Ambitious grocery shopping in week one becomes food waste in week two. Cook what... you already know until the kitchen works.

PART 6 The first month

Weeks 2–4

SET UP THE SYSTEMS

- [ ] **Autopay everything** — rent if you can, utilities, phone, insurance
- [ ] Put these on a calendar for the whole year, with reminders: rent (monthly) · air filter (every 1–3 months) · smoke detector batteries (yearly) · insurance renewal · **lease end date, and the notice deadline before it**
- [ ] Pick a **home for incoming mail** — process it standing up, near a recycling bin
- [ ] Pick a **home for important documents**: lease, insurance, pay stubs, anything with an account number
- [ ] Pick a **home for keys** by the door, and use it every time

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> A stack of mail is a stack of unmade decisions with deadlines attached. The stack isn't th... problem — the deferred decisions are.

SET THE RHYTHM

- [ ] **A ten-minute reset before bed** — dishes in, counters wiped, things put back
- [ ] **One weekly reset**, 45–90 minutes: laundry, bathroom, floors, fridge clear-out. Same day each week, so you stop deciding.
- [ ] Laundry on a schedule, not when you run out of clothes

WHY IT MATTERS

The nightly reset is the single habit that separates a place that stays livable from one tha... keeps getting worse. Skip it four days and you've got a project instead of ten minutes.

IF YOU HAVE ROOMMATES

- [ ] **Agree out loud who does what**, and write it down. Not "we'll both do the kitchen" — "you own dishes, I own trash and floors."
- [ ] Decide how shared bills are split, and *who actually pays the company*
- [ ] Agree on guests, quiet hours, and shared groceries **before** it's a problem
- [ ] Name the invisible work too: noticing supplies are low, taking out recycling, scheduling repairs. It's real work, and it's what people end up resenting.

COSTLY The five things that cost people the most

1. **Not documenting move-in condition.** Hundreds of dollars, every time.
2. **Missing the move-out notice deadline.** An extra month's rent.
3. **No renter's insurance.** One burst pipe replaces everything you own.
4. **Aspirational grocery shopping.** Produce rots; delivery fills the gap.
5. **Ignoring small repairs.** Report them in writing, early. A slow drip becomes a ceiling.

If you only do five things

Everything else on this list gets easier once these are true.

1. Photograph everything before you unpack.
2. Put every bill on autopay.
3. Find the water shutoff and the breaker panel.
4. Give things a home while you're unpacking.
5. Reset the kitchen for ten minutes before bed.

That's it. Five things, and the first month stops happening *to* you.

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